JAZZ LAB MUSIC

REHARM

A SHORT GUIDE TO REHARMONIZATION

4 MAIN REHARM TECHNIQUES

TRANSCRIPTIONS AND EXAMPLES



JAZZ LAB

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REHARM

Reharmonization is one of the main elements that shapes a jazz musician's artistic voice. Changing/replacing/adding/transforming the original chords of a tune can help add a sense of novelty, surprise, magic, humor and fun to harmonic progressions that are already over-played.

This book describes 4 excellent methods to get started. Some are based on theory, others are more intuitive. If you already have a stronger harnony background, feel free to try the harder methods, and use some of the chords suggested here. If you are just starting, read some of the transcriptions here, try to apply whatever you can understand, and use your ears to start pushing your boundaries. Feel free to email us if you have any questions.

Not every jazz piece needs to be reharmonized. Some ballads, or faster tunes are already complex enough, or fast enough, so there's no need to make it even more complex; it can actually play against you and make your performance poorer. We recommend reharmonizing tunes that are very simple, well known to everybody.

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- Q&A
- Basic concepts for those starting to play and understand theory/composition/improvisation.
- Advanced concetps (counterpoint, intervallic chords, composing successful melodies, arranging)
- Handouts, transcriptions, methods.

FRI 5/23 7-9pm
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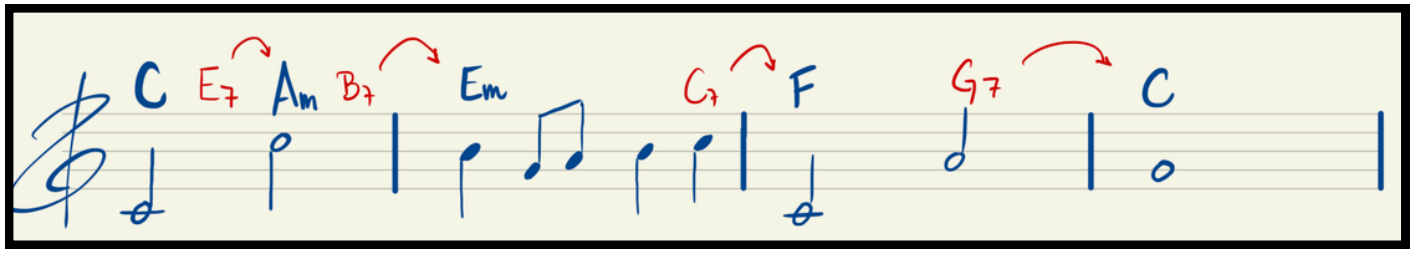
METHOD 1

TONAL SUBSTITUTIONS

We will be workshopping "Somewhere Over the Rainbow"; this is a great example of a beautiful simple tune that everybody knows, with plenty of space to reharmonize.

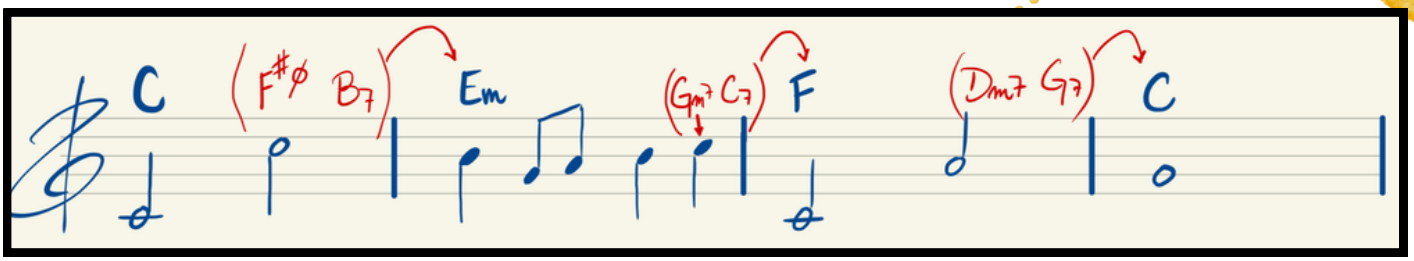


Tonal substitutions encompass all types of chords that can be explained by tonal relationships, for example, adding a dominant chord before each original chord of the tune. (Check out or "Juilliard Professor replaces a semester of music theory in 10 mins" video on Youtube if you need some visual help).

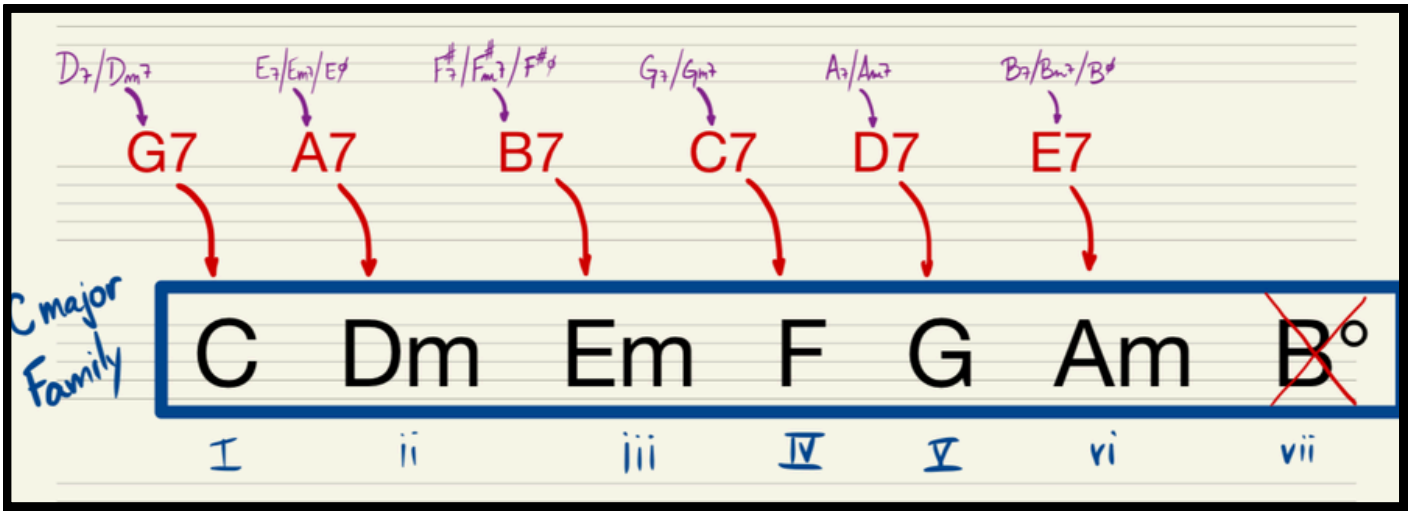


METHOD 1

You may also go a step further and add a ii-V for each of the original chords in the piece.



Below you can find a part of our chord matrix to help visualize the harmonic pathways to reach each chord of the C major family.

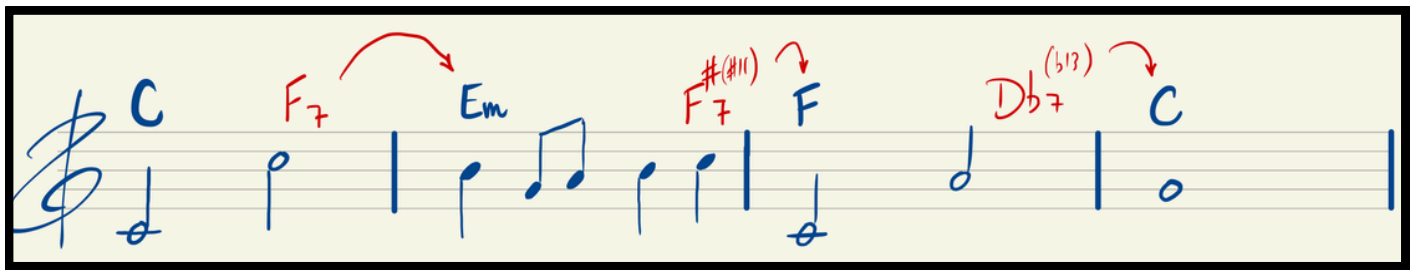


Try to experiment adding all sorts of secondary dominants in your reharmonization, by following the arrows on the matrix. Since this melody is all in the key of C major, there is a LOT of room for experimentation.

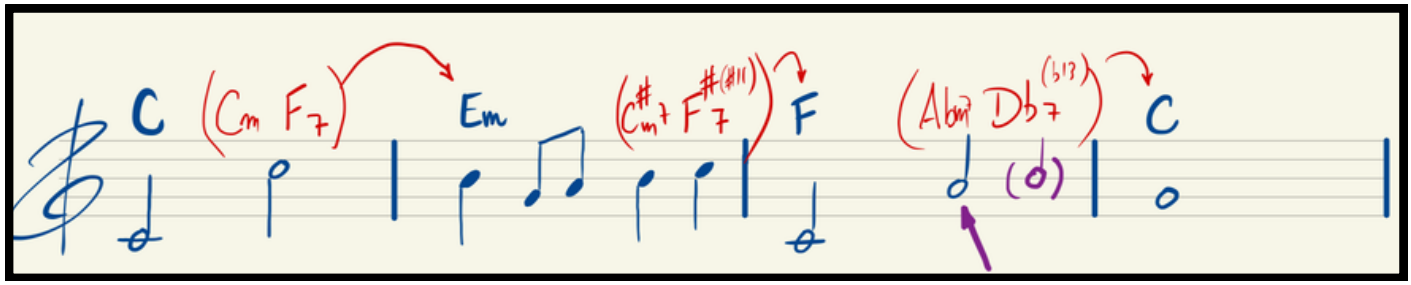
Another option is to completely replace the original chords from the tune by other chords from the C major family, for example starting on Am7 or Fmaj7 instead of C.

METHOD 1

If you are familiar with substitute dominants (replacing a dominant chord by another dominant chord a tritone away) you may also apply it here. I like to think about using a dominant chord half step above your target chord.



You may also experiment with substitue ii-V progressions; these can be a tritone sub ((using a ii-V a tritone away), or a ii-V a half step away from the original ii-V. The only challenge here is to make sure the the notes on the melody still fit those chords. In the example below, there's an issue on the 3rd measure: the substitute ii-V doesnt fit the melody note A. You can either apply a different reharm technique or slightly shift the melody (moving the A to a B temporarily as an ornament).



METHOD 1

TO SUMMARIZE

Using tonal substitutes is the most common reharmonization technique, because it can be easily explained by theory: utilizing tonal gravity (dominant-tonic) to explore different possibilities within the context of tonality.

PRACTICE SUGGESTION

Try reharmonizing the second half of this melody, or another easy tune. You may treat it as a parody; try to have some fun. Choose tunes with long notes and easy chords.

One common challenge is the lack of harmonic vocabulary when it comes to building chords (not having enough of an arsenal of different beautiful chords). I recommend borrowing some chords from the greats (maybe a Bill Evans transcriptions for example) and trying to apply these. Even if your harmonic vocabulary is small, start by memorizing one great complex chord and try using only that chord.

METHOD 2

PIVOT NOTES

THE PRINCIPLE

This is one of our favorite methods, very common in modern jazz. The idea is pick a few important notes of the melody and add a chord that has absolutely nothing to do with the tonality and chord family you are in. This chord should still contain the melody note you chose.



The circled notes above are good candidates for reharmonized chords. They will add tension, while still preserving the important cadences and harmonic movements from the original tune. Let's think about chords that are very distant from the C major family but that include the C note; One way to think about this is by asking yourself: what it this C is the 9th of a minor chord? Or the 13th of a sus chord? Or the 3rd of a maj7 chord?



METHOD 2

Notice that all these options result in chords that don't belong to the C major family nor to its immediate secondary dominants; this create a feeling of surprise, decoupling from the original key.

I recommend experimenting with complex chords, using upper structures, or more intricate orchestrations. For example, what if the note C is the #11 of a dominant chord, or the #5 of a maj7(#5), or the maj7 of a dim(maj7) chord?

If these are unfamiliar to you, use the chords that you currently know. Sometimes the better sounding choice isn't necessarily the most complext one.



PRACTICE: pick your pivot notes on your melody. For each of them, write an extensive list of every possible chord that could include that note; this list will be immense, and will require good knowledge on building voicings. Once you have a complete list, try each option in the context of the melody, and see which chords bring you the desire effect. You may try to apply this idea to each note on the melody, resulting in a crazy reharm, almost like a parody.

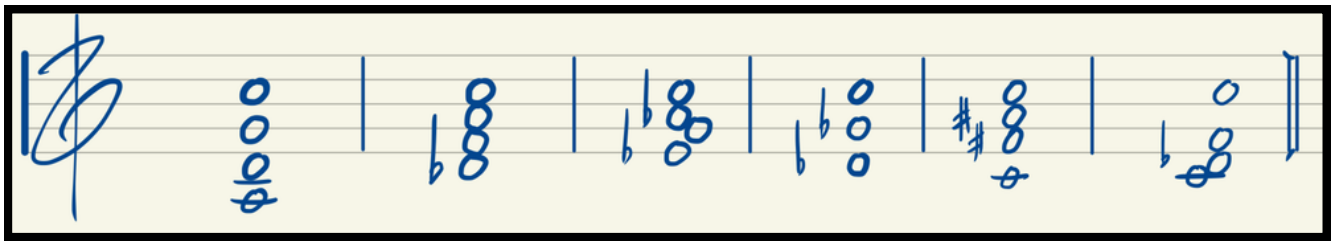
METHOD 3

PARALLEL CHORDS



This is a common technique in orchestral music, or large ensembles. It creates impressionist musical paisages. Ravel, Stravinsky, Gil Evans, George Russell, all used parallel chords frequently.

First, choose one chord that you really love, something with a really particular 'color': it doesn't have to be a complete chord, 3 or 4 notes are enough. You may think about them by stacking intervals, or borrowing from your favorite artists. For example, you may stack fourths, or use minor seconds and major thirds, or use a well known chord. Our focus will be on the top note.

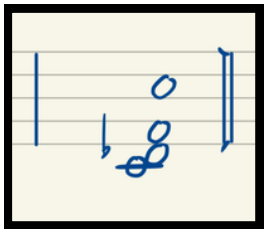


Here are some examples of chords built with unique combinations of intervals. Some sound very familiar, others are quite dissonant. Notice that all of them have the note C on top, since this will be our first melody note.

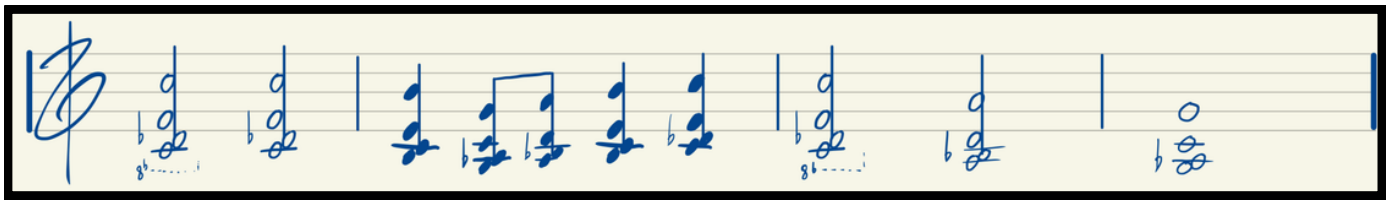
The next step is to pick one of these chords and apply it to every note of the melody, transposing chromatically up and down.

METHOD 3

In this example, lets choose the last chord of the list. It has been borrowed from Debussy's "*Claire de Lune*", and it's made out of a minor second followed by a major third and a perfect fifth.



Let's apply this exact chord to all of the notes in the melody of Somewhere over the Rainbow.



This is easier to play then to read, so use your intutition when transposing. This is particularly easy on guitar/bass.

This technique is also often accompanied by a drone, a pedal tone that is sustained for a long stretch, adding a completely new atmosphere to the reharm. Experiment a few different pedal tones, until you find one that you like. It is not going to sound tonal, but it may feel magical.

PRACTICE: try applying this technique to all the chords discussed on the previous page.

METHOD 4

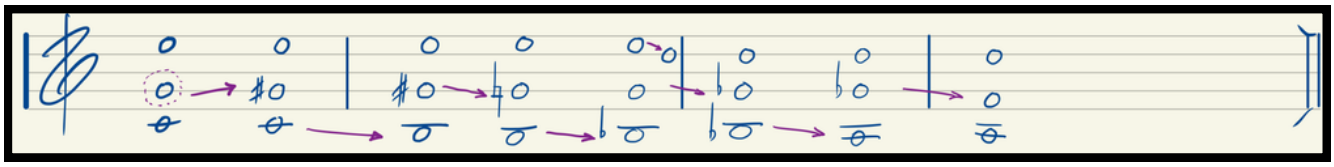
VOICE LEADING

This technique is rather open ended and require more experimentation and trial/error.

The idea is to have a starting chord and then slowly change only one note of that chord at a time, slowly mutating it into something else. The creative constraint of only moving one voice at a time will force you to find new sounds and unexpected solutions. The thinking here is rather horizontal, and not vertical.

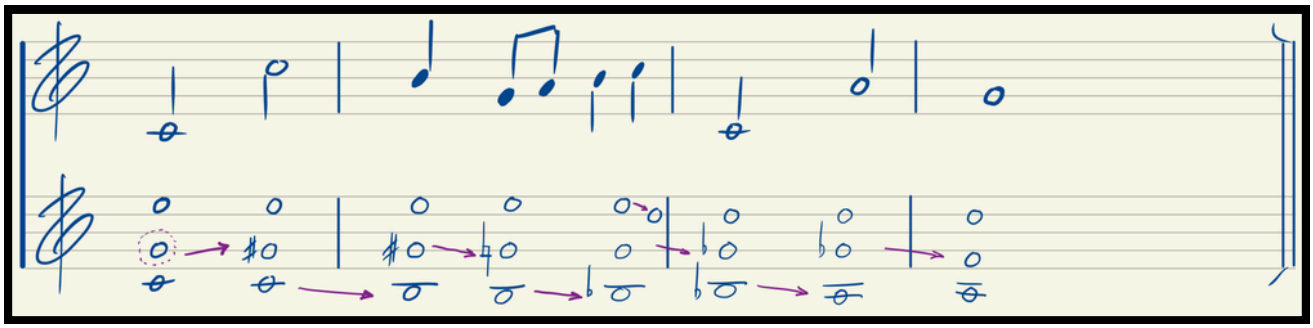
The main challenge is to make sure the melody fits this new surprising harmony. I recommend experimenting with a certain degree of carelessness. We sometimes may have an initial reaction of rejection to certain dissonances, but upon a second listening we may fall in love with them.

Start with a simple chord, maybe a major triad. Play it as an open chord (the third is played an octave higher se there's more space in between notes). Establish an ostinato or an arpeggio motion. After a few beats choose one of the 3 voices and move it up or down by a half step. The resulting chords don't have to be known chords.



METHOD 4

The example above was an improvisation, in which only one voice at a time is changed (only half step up/down). The harmonic rhythm is your choice (when to change each chord). As I was playing I was also analyzing whther the melody could fit the new chords. In this case, it does:

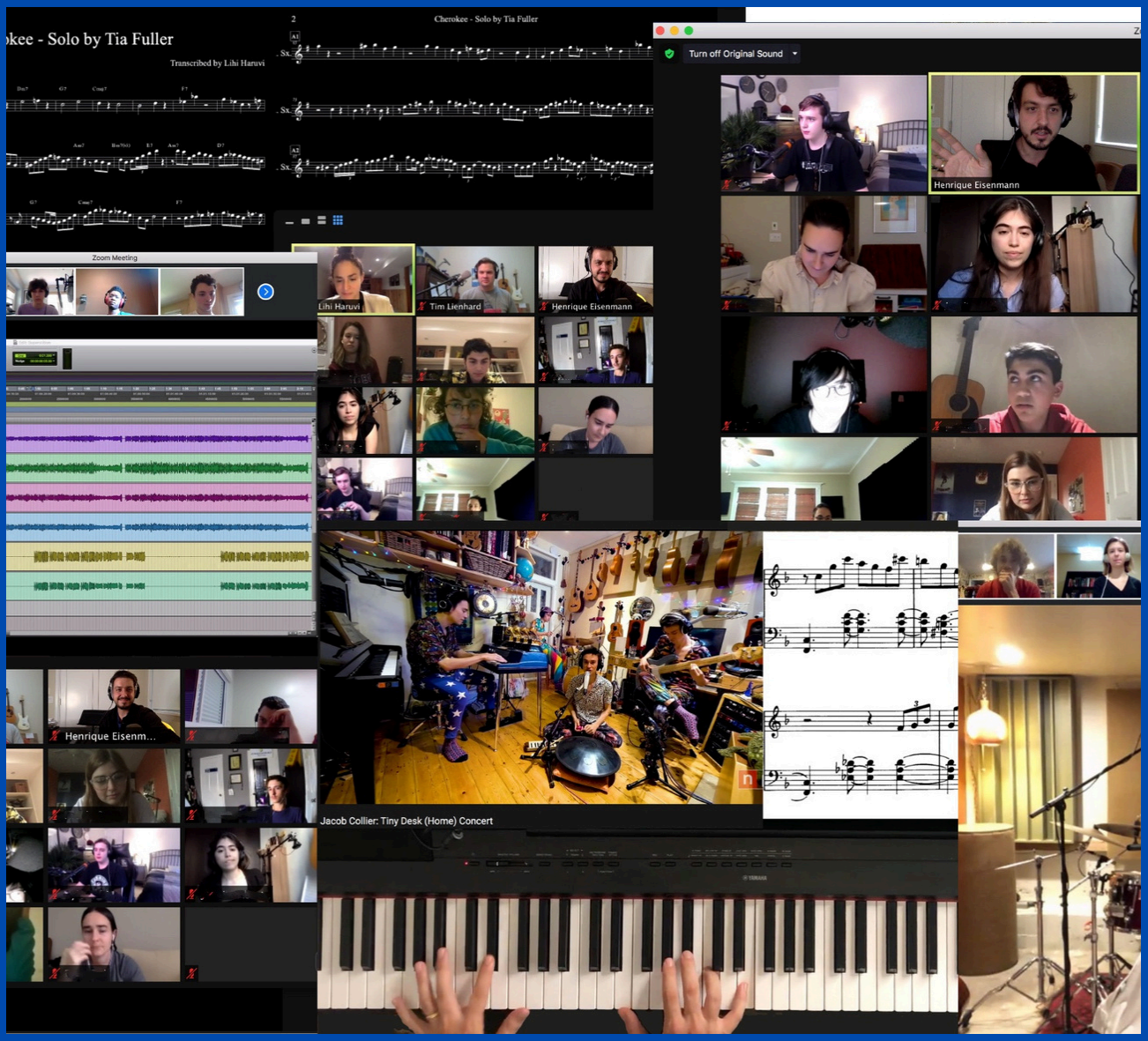


This technique requires you to play the melody really slowly, in order to have time to hear the subtle changes in color. It is an intutitve way to come up with new unexpected chords, utilizing very few voices. There's something special about creating such surprising shifts using so few notes. I personally love that more than reharmonizing with an 8 note gigantic chord.

Nevertheless, it is not that easy to come up with a voiceleading that fits the melody perfectly, so you may need to extend a few notes of the melody here and there, to try to accommodate the new chords.

PRACTICE: Create a few series of voice-led harmonies without a melody in mind, just playing a chord and slowly transforming it. Get familiar with the different possibilities and sounds you can obtain. Then try applying is to simple melodies. If you hit a wall, you may interrupt the voice leading as a last resort and shift the whole chord, although I believe there's ALWAYS a solution half-step away.

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